Research Statement

Kingsford Onyina
The University of North Carolina at Charlotte

My research lies at the intersection of poverty and income policy, child and family policy, and program evaluation. I study how the design, timing, and implementation of social safety nets shape the well-being of economically vulnerable populations over the life course and across generations. My work spans the United States and sub-Saharan Africa, with the broader goal of generating evidence to inform policies that expand economic opportunity.

My dissertation examines the spillover effects of social safety net design across three policy settings. The first two chapters study the Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) program and the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) in the United States. The third turns to Ghana's Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) 1000 program, one of the country's major unconditional cash transfer programs. I discuss each chapter below, followed by my prior research and future research agenda.

Welfare Reform and the Noncognitive Skill Formation of the Next Generation *(Job Market Paper)*

U.S. welfare reform in the 1990s replaced Aid to Families with Dependent Children, an entitlement, with Temporary Assistance for Needy Families, which tied assistance more closely to work requirements, sanctions, and time limits. Early research focused on mothers' employment and caseloads, and a later literature documented consequences for children's health, home environments, schooling, and behavior. Much less is known about the reform's socioemotional legacy, even though these traits predict earnings, employment, and health in adulthood and are most responsive to environmental inputs during the early years in which reform reorganized family care.

My job market paper asks whether early-life exposure to welfare reform left a lasting imprint on these skills. Using the Panel Study of Income Dynamics and its Child Development and Transition into Adulthood Supplements, I exploit variation in reform exposure across states, birth cohorts, and mothers' likelihood of being affected in a triple-difference design. Among children of mothers most likely to be affected, full early-life exposure reduced noncognitive skills in young adulthood by roughly a quarter of a standard deviation, with declines concentrated in agreeableness and openness. The decline appears among children reached before the fifth birthday and not among those first exposed later in childhood.

The mechanism evidence points to changes in the organization of early care. Reform increased reliance on formal childcare, while household income and maternal employment changed little. I then use state exemptions that shield mothers of young children from work requirements to sharpen this interpretation. Adverse effects concentrate in exposure accumulated after the child aged past a state's exemption threshold, when the requirement bound on the mother, and are muted while she remained exempt. The timing of work requirements is therefore a design margin with developmental consequences.

I also follow these cohorts into the labor market. The traits reform moved most are negatively associated with earnings in this sample, the reduced-form earnings estimate is positive but imprecise, and employment rises. A developmental loss of this kind therefore need not surface in the conventional economic outcomes observed during the transition to adulthood. More broadly, the paper sets up my agenda on how the design of social policy shapes outcomes beyond the adults whose behavior it regulates, and over horizons longer than evaluations usually observe.

Does Expanding SNAP Eligibility Reduce Crime? Evidence from Broad-Based Categorical Eligibility

Evidence linking food assistance to crime generally studies the amount, timing, delivery, or withdrawal of benefits among populations already eligible for assistance. Less is known about whether the rules determining who can access SNAP in the first place have broader effects on criminal behavior. This distinction matters because states have considerable discretion over eligibility rules, creating an important but understudied dimension of program design.

My second dissertation chapter studies this question using Broad-Based Categorical Eligibility (BBCE), which thirty-two states adopted between 2000 and 2010 to expand SNAP eligibility by waiving the asset test and, in many cases, raising the gross income ceiling above the federal limit of 130 percent of the poverty line. Because BBCE changes access to the program without changing the federal benefit formula, it isolates the effects of expanded eligibility from those of benefit generosity. I combine state SNAP policy and participation data with arrest records that individual police departments and sheriff's offices report to the FBI, covering 2,784 agencies from 1996 through 2016, and exploit the staggered adoption across states in a stacked difference-in-differences design.

I find that expanding SNAP eligibility increases program participation and reduces arrests of adults aged 18 and over, for a total offense index and for violent and property offenses. These findings are robust across alternative comparison groups, estimators, samples, and treatment definitions. The paper shows that eligibility rules can generate effects beyond program participation and spending, highlighting criminal justice contact as an additional margin through which the design of food assistance may affect social well-being.

Cash Transfers and the Labor Supply of Vulnerable Households and Individuals: Does Household Indebtedness Matter? *(with Danny Turkson, University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill)*

Cash transfer programs are often evaluated by whether they reduce beneficiaries' incentives to work. Yet this framing overlooks an important feature of low-income households: many enter these programs already carrying debt. For indebted households, additional income may therefore relax financial constraints, finance productive activities, or increase the need to generate earnings for repayment, making labor-supply responses different from those of otherwise similar beneficiaries.

My third dissertation chapter examines this question using Ghana's Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) 1000 program, an unconditional cash transfer targeted to poor households with pregnant women and young children. Exploiting the program's experimental design, we examine whether pre-existing household indebtedness conditions the effect of cash transfers on labor supply across wage employment, agriculture, and nonfarm enterprise activity.

We find that the cash transfer generally reduces labor supply, but this response differs substantially among indebted beneficiaries. Households with debt increase labor supplied to wage employment and nonfarm enterprises, with particularly strong responses when debt was incurred for productive investment. These findings show that household financial obligations can shape how beneficiaries respond to income support and help reconcile seemingly conflicting evidence on the labor-supply effects of cash transfers. More broadly, the paper highlights household balance sheets as an important but often overlooked source of heterogeneity in social protection policy.

Prior Research

Before my dissertation, I built a research program on social protection, household welfare, and institutional engagement in sub-Saharan Africa. In joint work, I find that broader social-protection coverage is associated with more inclusive growth across the region, that international remittances

strengthen multiple dimensions of women's empowerment, and that agricultural extension services improve household assets, food consumption, and dietary diversity in Ghana. A consistent theme is that resources delivered through public programs and private transfers translate into household wellbeing unevenly, in ways that depend on economic and social context, the same heterogeneity that motivates my current work.

A second line examines how citizens understand and engage with policy and public institutions, while extending my quantitative work across disciplinary settings. In my sole-authored *"Universal Access, Divided Opinions,"* published in *Social Policy and Society*, I use latent class analysis to show that Ghana's universal Free Senior High School policy produced distinct configurations of public opinion rather than uniform support. Joint work on corruption reporting examines how education, economic security, civic engagement, and trust shape citizens' willingness to use formal accountability institutions, while an R & R at *Electoral Studies* uses Lewbel's heteroskedasticity-based IV approach to examine how knowledge of voting requirements shapes voter confidence.

Extending this interest in how policy design shapes public attitudes, my paper *"Burden or Necessity? Experimental Evidence on Public Perceptions of SNAP's Work Requirement for College Students,"* currently under review at *Administration & Society*, uses a randomized survey experiment to examine how the perceived administrative burden of SNAP work requirements affects public support. I find that support declines as the burden imposed on students becomes more salient, including among conservatives when structural constraints are emphasized. This work reinforces a broader theme in my research: policy design influences not only material outcomes, but also how citizens interpret, evaluate, and respond to public programs.

Future Directions

Building on my dissertation, my U.S. research agenda will continue to examine how social safety-net design shapes the well-being of economically vulnerable populations over the life course and across generations. Building on my JMP, I plan to study whether early-life exposure leaves lasting effects on health, economic mobility, and criminal justice contact, and ultimately whether these effects persist into a third generation. Regarding my SNAP-BBCE work, I will examine whether expanded access affects mortality and other health outcomes. More broadly, I plan to study how overlapping eligibility across programs such as TANF, SNAP, SSI, WIC, the EITC, and the Child Tax Credit shapes financial security, labor-market behavior, and children's development.

In sub-Saharan Africa, I will continue studying social protection, with an emphasis on the interaction between public and private safety nets. Households often rely simultaneously on government transfers, informal support, and international remittances. I plan to examine when these resources complement or substitute for one another and how their composition shapes investment, resilience, labor supply, human capital formation, and longer-run mobility.

Finally, I plan to complement quasi-experimental methods with microsimulation to assess the distributional and long-run consequences of proposed reforms before their effects are fully observed. This agenda creates opportunities for external support from USDA, NIH, NSF, the Russell Sage Foundation, the Robert Wood Johnson Foundation, and funders focused on social protection and poverty reduction in sub-Saharan Africa.